undermined it, perhaps irretrievably. For the first time, Opposition benches trained their guns on the chief executive himself, crying out that Dr Singh's white kurta was stained with the taint of tolerating corruption. An entire Parliament session would be stalled over the issue.

Leading the charge against the government on 2G was Dr Subramanian Swamy, keen to resurrect his political career. Dr Swamy claimed to be a personal friend of Dr Singh, but had a visceral hatred for Sonia. Evil genius or brave crusader, he was not someone you wanted to make an enemy of. Once, when we cancelled him from a studio debate at the last minute, he warned me, 'Sonia Gandhi must have told you not to have me in the programme. I will expose you on Twitter!' A meticulous gatherer of allegedly incriminating material against his rivals, Dr Swamy took the 2G battle to the courts and made it even more difficult for the UPA-II government to try and distance itself from Raja.

It wasn't just Raja who became synonymous with corruption—there was also the figure of Rs 1.76 lakh crore that stuck in the public imagination. 'Ten zeroes' appeared to suggest that corruption had multiplied ten times, and led to a flurry of jokes on the Internet and social media. The figure seemed outlandish but the only minister ready to challenge the CAG's calculations was the newly appointed telecom minister Kapil Sibal. 'There can be nothing like "presumptive" loss. There is no loss at all, it is zero loss,' said Sibal in his interviews.

Sibal's charge was based on a complex legal–technical argument, claiming that the CAG's calculations had to be discounted because of various factors, including the maximizing of public welfare as a result of cheap mobile telephony. It may have been a persuasive argument in a courtroom, but Sibal was not a lead counsel appearing before a Supreme Court bench; he was a minister of the government appearing before the court of public opinion. And a disbelieving public found it incredible that a minister was using the word 'zero loss' when the CAG had pegged the loss at a whopping Rs 1.76 lakh crore.

'You people in the media were very unfair to us, very unfair,' Sibal would later tell me. 'I was never defending Raja. I always said that the criminal